In



HOMAGE TO FREE-THINKING *Pradip Krishen, the director of* Annie, *in Delhi*

YASIR IQBAL

her recently published memoir *Mother Mary Comes to Me,* Arundhati Roy dedicates a whole chapter to the 1989 English-language Doordarshan film *In Which Annie Gives It Those Ones*, for which she had won a National Award for best screenplay. Set in 1974, Annie is the story of dreamers, drawing heavily on Roy's time at Delhi's School of Planning and Architecture. It follows Anand 'Annie' Grover, played by Arjun Raina, who imagined trees planted along train tracks getting fertilised by the faeces of the poor who defecated there, with the sprinklers of passing trains watering them, as a means to achieving utopia. Over the years, *Annie* and its zany idealism quietly lived on in the annals of the internet in a patchy print, gathering a cult following. Now, 37 years after its release, *Annie* has finally been restored by the Film Heritage Foundation, and is slated to premiere at the Berlin International Film Festival on February 16.

"I haven't seen the restored version, I saw clips of it, and I feel like even the restored version still has this slightly scrappy quality to it," Roy says, referring to the unkemptness and audacity of the characters. Like watching a court jester perform cartwheels, *Annie* tumbled out of Roy's hand onto the page in three weeks, through which the writer refused to leave her room in her Malcha Marg home. What emerged was an unselfconscious caper about a group of students who help the quixotic Annie graduate from college after four failed attempts. Roy is adamant that this was possible because no one was in it for the money or the fame. "It was ambitious only in that we were demanding the right to be idiosyncratic," she says.

CASTING ACTORS FOR THE ROLES WAS BASED ON HOW THEY PERFORMED AT THE WORKSHOPS. SHAH RUKH WAS A REGULAR; MANOJ BAJPAYEE WAS NOT

Pradip Krishen, the director, remembers it much the same way. It took about two meetings with the then director general of Doordarshan, Bhaskar Ghose, to greenlight *Annie*. But what had taken Krishen by surprise was someone wanting to learn about the subcultures of the world they inhabited.

The actors were found through rigorous workshops, and Krishen remembers Shah Rukh Khan being a regular at those sessions. Khan, fresh out of lead roles in Doordarshan serials *Dil Dariya* and *Fauji*, was "not used to begging for roles", Krishen recalls the actor telling him. But he was sincerely hoping to be cast as Mankind. "I said, 'Shah Rukh, I am sorry, but I have already decided who's going to play Mankind, it's a guy called Isaac Thomas.' And he was very disappointed." Assessing the cast members and assigning them roles was based on how they had performed at the workshops, Krishen says, and Manoj